

## CORE FORMULA

Their moment -> acknowledge -> follow-up -> optional brief bridge -> return -> "That sounds [specific quality]. What was [the alive part]?" -> "I have a version of that too, but I want to stay with yours first. What happened next?" -> "That reminds me of something similar, but your part is the interesting bit here: what did you do after that?"

## MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before saying "me too", ask one more question about their story.

## BEST FOR

- When someone shares a win, achievement, compliment, or proud moment.
- When someone shares hardship, stress, embarrassment, vulnerability, or frustration.
- When you feel a strong impulse to say "me too", "same", "that's nothing", or "when I?".
- Networking, dating, friendships, workplace rapport, group conversations, and leadership.
- Any situation where likability depends on making the other person feel interesting, not overshadowed.

## PHRASE BANK

### Default support responses · All-purpose openers

- "That sounds like a big moment. What was the best part?"
- "There's more in that than the headline. What happened next?"
- "That sounds like it mattered. What made it important?"
- "I want to hear your version properly. How did it play out?"
- "That's interesting. What was the turning point?"
- "What did you make of it at the time?"

### When tempted to say "me too" · Catch and redirect the impulse

- "I've had a version of that, but yours sounds more interesting. What happened next?"
- "That resonates, but I don't want to make it about me. What was it like for you?"
- "I'm tempted to tell my similar story, but first: what was the hardest part of yours?"
- "I can relate to the feeling. What did you do after that?"
- "I've been in the neighbourhood of that, but not exactly. What made yours different?"
- "Before I tell my version, I want to hear how yours ended."

### Responding to a win · Let them savour it

- "That's a proper win. When did it sink in?"
- "You should actually enjoy that one. What part took the most work?"
- "That's not a small thing. What made it happen?"
- "What was the moment where you thought, 'this is actually working'?"
- "Who was the first person you told?"
- "What did you do differently that made it come together?"

### Responding to hardship · Do not compete with pain

- "That sounds heavy. What made it hardest?"
- "That sounds like a lot to carry. What helped you get through it?"
- "I can see why that stayed with you. What part still sticks?"
- "That sounds less annoying and more draining. Is that right?"
- "What did people miss about how hard that was?"

- "What would have helped at the time?"

### **Professional, leadership & groups · Work, meetings, and group amplifying**

- "That probably took more coordination than it looks. What was the key move?"
- "You made that sound simple, but I'm guessing it wasn't. What was the constraint?"
- "That's a useful insight. What led you to that read?"
- "Good call. What did you notice that others missed?"
- "That's your win. What should we learn from it?"
- "I want to come back to what Sam just said, because that was the useful part."
- "Before I add my view, I think Priya's point deserves a second."
- "Can we stay with that for a moment? There's a good lesson in it."

### **Social / dating · Playful, warm, low-pressure**

- "Wait, that's your story. I want the director's cut."
- "You can't drop that and let me hijack it. What happened?"
- "I have a related story, but yours has priority. Continue."
- "That sounds like the actual interesting part. Go on."
- "I'm resisting the urge to make this about me, which is very mature of me. What happened next?"
- "That deserves more than a polite "nice". What was the best bit?"

### **Digital / text · One-line messages**

- "That's a big deal. What happened after?"
- "I'm not going to make this about my similar story — tell me the full version."
- "That sounds like it took more than people would realise."
- "What was the best part of that?"
- "I can relate, but I want to understand your version first."
- "That sounds intense. What made it hardest?"

### **Repair / reset · After you have hijacked the thread**

- "I just made that about me. Sorry — go back."
- "That came out as a one-up. Not what I meant."
- "I jumped in too fast. What I should have asked is..."
- "Let me rewind. Your point was the important one."
- "I think I hijacked the thread. Continue from where you were."
- "I answered with my story before I understood yours. My bad."

## **WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST**

- Weak: "Same thing happened to me."  
Better: "I've had a version of that."  
**Best: "I've had a version of that, but yours sounds more complicated. What happened next?"**
- Weak: "That's nothing."  
Better: "That sounds intense."  
**Best: "That sounds intense in a way people might not realise. What was the hardest part?"**
- Weak: "I know exactly how you feel."  
Better: "I can relate to part of that."  
**Best: "I can relate to part of that, though I don't want to assume it was the same. What was it like for you?"**
- Weak: "Mine was worse."  
Better: "That sounds rough."  
**Best: "That sounds rough. What do you think people missed about how hard it was?"**

## **DECISION TREE**

### **If They share a win**

Celebrate and ask about the moment, effort, or meaning before mentioning any win of your own.

*"That's a proper win. What part took the most work?"*

#### **If They share hardship**

Validate and ask what made it hardest. Do not compete with pain.

*"That sounds heavy. What made it hardest?"*

#### **If They ask if it happened to you**

Answer briefly, then hand it straight back to them.

*"A bit, but yours sounds different — what was it like for you?"*

#### **If You have already one-upped**

Name it lightly and repair, without over-apologising.

*"I just made that about me. Sorry — go back."*

#### **If Group story-sharing starts**

Amplify the current speaker before adding your own story.

*"Can we stay with that a second? There's a good lesson in it."*

#### **If They go flat after your story**

Cut it short, reflect, and ask about them again.

*"Anyway, yours is the point — what happened after?"*

## **SCENARIOS**

### **Social conversation**

Use the smallest natural version so the other person feels heard without being analysed. — "That sounds like the best bit. What happened next?"

### **Professional discussion**

Keep it concise and tie the move to the task, decision, or concern. — "That's your call to make. What led you there?"

### **Conflict or objection**

Add validation and reduce speed; do not weaponise the technique. — "I want to understand your version before I add mine."

### **Digital message**

Use one sentence. Avoid long explanations or stacked questions. — "That's a big deal — what was the best part?"

### **Shy or guarded person**

Make the move lighter, more tentative, and lower pressure. — "No rush, but I'd like to hear more if you're up for it."

### **High-status or busy person**

Keep the wording brief, grounded, and useful. — "Good call. What did you notice that others missed?"

## **WHEN NOT TO USE**

- They directly ask for your story, experience, view, or advice.
- The conversation has clearly become mutual story-swapping and both people are enjoying the rhythm.
- Your related story is genuinely useful, brief, and you can return the focus quickly.
- A direct answer is needed more than rapport-building.
- You are withholding so much that the conversation becomes an interview — the goal is generous timing, not silence.

## **7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL**

### **Day 1 — Spot the impulse**

For a whole day, silently notice every time you want to say "same", "me too", "that's nothing", or "when I?". Just count them; change nothing yet.

### **Day 2 — One extra question**

In five conversations, before sharing anything about yourself, ask one follow-up about their story first.

### **Day 3 — Bridge and return**

When you do share, keep it to two sentences, then hand the focus straight back with a question about them.

### **Day 4 — Win practice**

Find someone sharing good news and centre their win — ask what part took the most work — without mentioning any win

of your own.

#### **Day 5 — Hardship practice**

When someone shares something hard, validate and ask what made it hardest, resisting any urge to match it with your own difficulty.

#### **Day 6 — Group amplify**

In a group, credit or amplify one person's point before you add your own: "That point matters — I'd add?".

#### **Day 7 — Repair and review**

Catch one moment you slip into competing, name it lightly, and return the spotlight. Then review the week: did you add connection or competition?

### **AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST**

- Did I let their story have the first turn?
- Did I avoid comparing intensity, success, hardship, or expertise?
- Did I ask at least one follow-up before sharing?
- If I shared, did I bridge and return the focus?
- Did they seem more open, animated, or respected afterwards?
- Did I repair quickly if I hijacked the thread?